

external drives comparison test this month, we also thought it was pertinent for you to know what to look for when buying an external drive.

Specs that matter

Capacity

Well, there is no such thing as enough capacity. The digital hoarders that we all are, we always need more space to store our photographs, that vacation video, those HD movies and so on. So you need to decide for yourself how much capacity will be ideal for you. If you just want to store photographs and music, we feel a 500GB drive is more than enough. If you want to store photos, music, movies, games, then look at a 1TB drive at the very least. But then one day you will eventually run out of whatever capacity you buy today.

Interface

This may have been a critical question a couple of years back for Windows users, but now it's a no-brainer. USB 3.0 drives are the way to go. Most of the laptops and motherboards these days come with a USB 3.0 port and it offers a significant speed bump over USB 2.0 drives. What's more, USB 3.0 is backwards compatible with USB 2.0, so fret not if you do not have a USB 3.0 port currently, the USB 3.0 drives will work fine with USB 2.0 ports as well. For those using older systems, USB 3.0 drives are a means of future proofing. For Apple users however, if you are not using the 2012 line of MacBook Pros and the MacBook Air then you will not find a USB 3.0 port. For such devices, if you want to go faster than the USB 2.0 standard, opt for a drive with a FireWire 800 interface. These days you are also getting a lot of drives with a Thunderbolt interface, but they are really expensive.

Portable or powered?

Portable drives are those that do not require a power supply whereas powered drives house a 3.5-inch drive which require external power. So when should one opt for which? If you are the kind who likes to carry data around, are a sucker for compactness, then the portable drive is the way to go. And with capacities going upto 2 TB there is enough space for all your needs. Powered drives offer a much more

economical cost per GB as compared to portable drives. They are comparatively bulky and require a constant power supply to work. These kinds of drives are ideal if you are not going to move the drive around. If you want a drive that will sit alongside your computer, or a drive to backup the data on your system externally, then opt for a powered drive.

Rugged drives

These kinds of drives are quite easy to recognise. They will most probably have a rubber casing, with the USB ports sealed from the environment. The drive within is not only water resistant but also capable of surviving falls, as it has shock absorbers which prevent the drive from getting damaged. These kinds of drives are ideal for people who will be accessing their drives outdoors. Also if you have buttery fingers, then don't bother going for drives with a glossy finish, opt for one with a rubber casing. These drives are priced at a slight premium which is understandable.

NAS drives

If you are a household where you have a desktop, a couple of laptops, a tablet and some smartphones, basically multiple devices, it makes sense to go for a NAS drive. A NAS drive or Network Attached Storage drive basically connects to your router and users can access data on that drive via the wireless or wired network. So instead of having to pass around the external drive with your movies around the house, you can store it all on one drive and many users can access that drive at the same time. You get capacities as high as 4TB in the NAS segment.

DECISION TIME SSDS

If you are considering upgrading your system in the mid-range budget, give SSDs a thought. If you are not going to use any heavy applications or are not so concerned with speedy access, then opt instead for a good 7200 RPM drive. Of course, that is no match for an SSD, but if you do not need that kind of speed then avoid the SSD.

If you have a lot of games and are tired of waiting for them to load, get an SSD and see the improvement in speeds. An ideal system should have an SSD+HDD combination with the SSD having the OS and a couple of heavy applications (which take ages to load on an HDD) and an HDD for storing your data. Don't contemplate an SSD if all you want is more capacity. SSDs are meant to improve your overall system performance and are not ideal to be used as storage drives.

NAND memory prices are expected to come down by the end of the year - which will make SSDs cheaper. So keep an eye on the prices and if you can, postpone your SSD buying till the end of the year.

Utilities to consider

A lot of drives these days come with a lot of utilities bundled with the drive. The very least you should expect are backup and encryption utilities. Backup is necessary to have a copy of your data, you can schedule backups and so on. It's best to use the Sync option, so that whenever you update something on your system it will get synced with your external drive. Encryption of data helps keep it secure.

Length of interface wire

Make sure the length of the interfacing wire is respectable enough. There are some drives which come with the interface



When it comes to external hard drives, make sure you get USB 3.0 interface drives, even if you don't have the connector. Future-proofing is the smartest way to buy